



4-all. Fritz staved off three break points of his own in the fifth game and another in the 11th. "Is there a better pure competitor in tennis than Taylor Fritz?" asked Courier, himself a terrific competitor in the 1990s.

A tiebreaker concluded one of the best matches of the year. It ended with a bang for the bolder Fritz, who walloped two forehand winners and a swinging backhand winner, and with a whimper for the passive Zverev, who committed three unforced forehand errors.

"Zverev doesn't have trust in his A-game the way Fritz does," observed Courier. "Sascha is trying to trust it and make his forehand a weapon [like Fritz's]. Just settling into backhand [crosscourt] rallies works against most players, but not the top players."

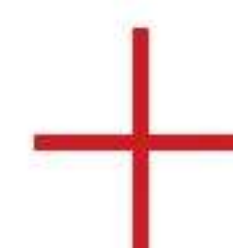
Now Fritz is firmly established as

a top player, at least in his own mind. "I have a lot of belief in myself. Love-40 [holds] is not as much out of reach [anymore]," he said after notching his 10th top-10 win of the year — the most by an American man since 1999, when Agassi had 12 and Sampras 10.

"I trust my game and my level, and I don't feel nearly as uncomfortable in these situations

anymore because I've been playing the top guys at big events a lot lately. I'm getting more comfortable in the moment. I'm really, really confident in my game."

Although Fritz has climbed to a career-best No. 4, he will need to improve his volleys and athleticism to upend Sinner and Alcaraz in best-of-five-set encounters at the Majors. "I did surprise myself with



In the semifinal between Zverev (above) and Fritz, both players displayed powerful groundstrokes, excellent mobility, and grit.